

COM11 · GRAPHIC DESIGN · PLANNING LAB

Plan the message. Then build the ad.

Use the free Excalidraw browser editor for the mood board, and Photoshop artboards to compare two layouts. Explain, test and revise your decisions.

8 illustrated stages

2 proposed 70-minute classes

Free browser mood board + Photoshop

Draft: native capture incomplete

MOOD BOARD / WHAT IT COMMUNICATES

NORTHCOAST / QUIET MOMENT

MOOD BOARD - constructed practice example

IMAGE DIRECTION



Calm space - one clear focal object

PALETTE ROLES

Cream / background

Dark / readable words

Terracotta / accent

Small accent, clear contrast

TYPE + TONE

Find your quiet moment

Simple sans serif / clear information

Calm - warm - uncluttered

WHY THESE REFERENCES?

One focal object and generous space support a calm tone. Dark words carry the message; the warm accent marks the action.

Original illustration + Dejavu Sans. Not a Photoshop screenshot.

Image treatment: calm, simple, one focal object

Colour roles: background, words, action

Type roles: headline, detail, tone

Annotations: why each choice serves this audience

Original teaching model. This image does not show Photoshop controls.

Start with a real message

Insert this module before the independent design in the main lab route. It is a supplement, not a calendar change. Use a teacher-approved actual school/community brief.

Browser-first route: stage 1 → free browser mood-board lab → Photoshop stages 2–3 → place the PNG in stage 4. No additional software installation is required.

Photoshop procedure not yet fully run. Native captures stop after creation of the first artboard with an incorrect height. Further per-action screenshots, correction, saved PSD and reopen/export proof are pending. This section needs a live teacher demonstration before student use.

[Download the planning log](#) · [Download original model images](#) · [Open the narrated planning presentation](#)

Why a designer does this

Discuss direction early, compare alternatives and show a client the reason for a choice. A mood board proposes a look and tone. A thumbnail proposes the arrangement. A prototype lets you test the reading experience.

Knowledge first

Mood board: references for images, colour, type and tone, with reasons. **Artboard:** a named canvas within a Photoshop file. **Thumbnail:** a rough composition. One artboard can hold a mood board; other artboards can hold sketches.

What your teacher reviews

How your design serves the audience, uses graphic principles, colour and type, compares options, and improves after evidence. Your teacher reviews the design, your explanation and how you respond to a changed brief. Completing the instructions is practice.

SESSION A · LESSON 1

Set a direction before you design

70 minutes suggested: 5 recall, 12 concept teaching/checks, 10 brief, 25 setup/reference planning, 10 explain, 8 save/check.
Teacher verifies native demonstration first.

01 Name the communication problem

Start here: read or listen to the [theory deck](#) (about 10 minutes, with checkpoint questions), then come back.

DOCUMENT: planning-log.txt

SELECT: Approved school/community brief

TOOLS / ROUTE: Brief → audience → action → constraints

1. Choose one actual approved message from the four director choices in the main lab route. Verify wording, dates, location and image permission with your teacher.
2. Write: “My audience is _____. After viewing, I want them to _____. They will see this at _____.”
3. Record the exact size and required information. For this digital practice use 1080 × 1350 px; change it only when the real delivery brief requires it.

A PLAN MAKES YOUR CHOICES VISIBLE

1 / BRIEF

Audience +
action

2 / DIRECTION

Mood +
references

3 / OPTIONS

Sketch A +
sketch B

4 / TEST

Response +
revision

Keep the first attempt. Explain the change using visible evidence.

Original teaching diagram · not a Photoshop interface

Original diagram: brief → direction → options → test.

WHY

A design succeeds when the right reader can find the message and action.

CHECK

Your brief names a particular audience and observable next action.

FIX

Replace “everyone” and “looks nice” with a reader, setting and action.

02 Create one named artboard

DOCUMENT: New Photoshop document

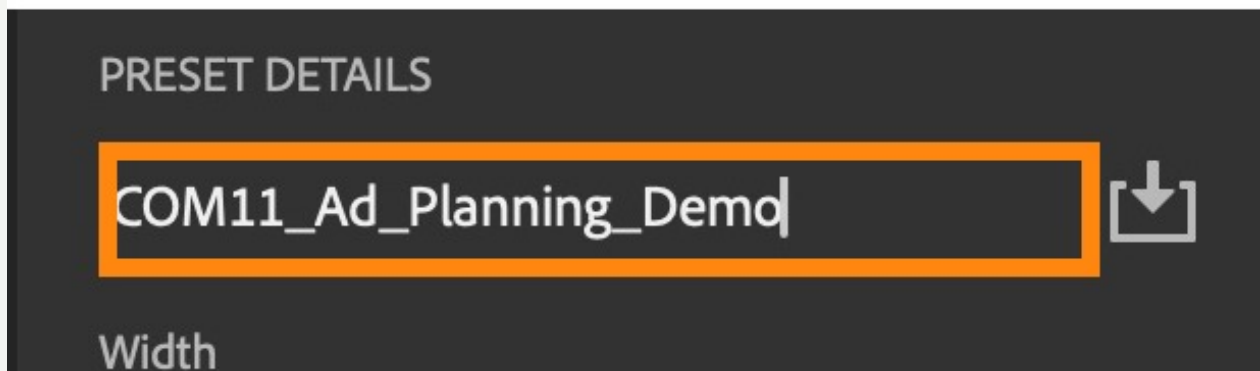
SELECT: No existing learner document

TOOLS / ROUTE: File → New → Artboards

1. Open File → New and name the document surname_AdPlanning_v01. Screenshot of the File menu is pending.
2. Set Width 1080 Pixels. Set Height 1350 Pixels separately; confirm the displayed value. Correct-height action screenshot is pending.
3. Check Artboards. Use RGB Color, 8 bit, White and sRGB; set Resolution 72 Pixels/Inch for this screen practice.
4. Choose Create. Select the artboard and confirm W 1080 / H 1350 in Properties. The observed build mistakenly kept H 2400; do not copy that height.

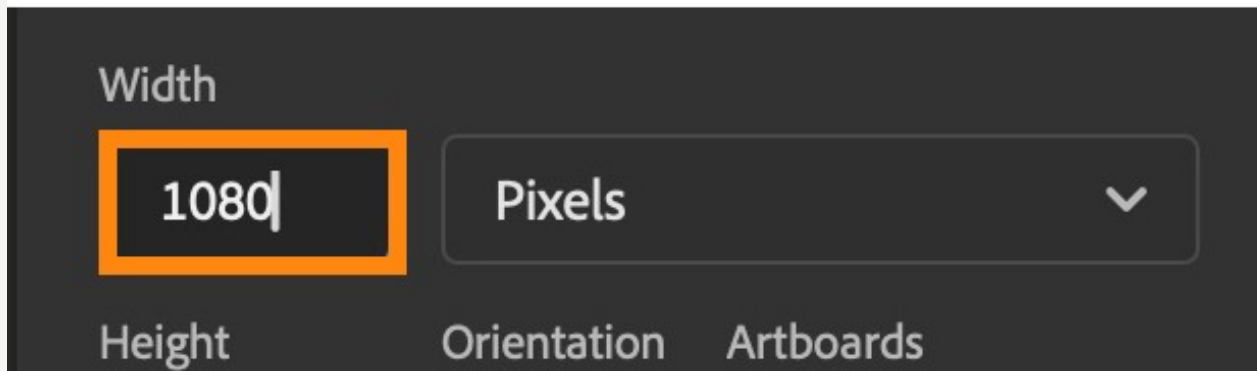
Photoshop procedure not yet fully run. Native captures stop after creation of the first artboard with an incorrect height. Further per-action screenshots, correction, saved PSD and reopen/export proof are pending. This section needs a live teacher demonstration before student use.

Action 2.1 / genuine capture



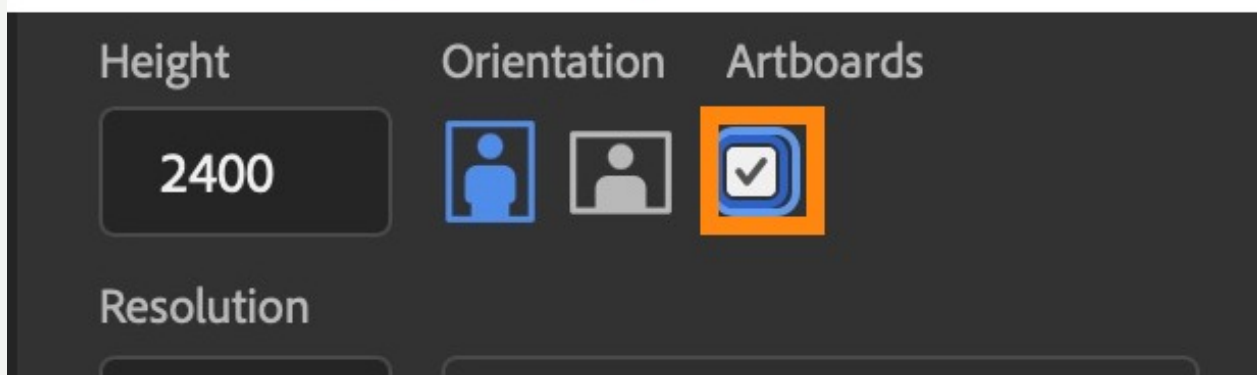
2.1 Genuine capture: document name. Height is still the inherited 2400 px; it must be changed.

Action 2.2 / genuine capture



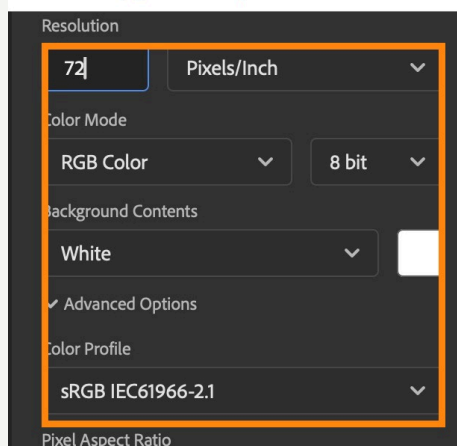
2.2 Genuine capture: width 1080 px. This is one dimension only.

Action 2.4 / genuine capture



2.4 Genuine capture: Artboards checked. The incorrect height remains visible.

Action 2.5 / genuine capture



2.5 Genuine capture: 72 PPI, RGB/8 and sRGB. These do not correct the pixel height.

WHY

The artboard defines the intended output frame. Pixel dimensions, not a screen PPI label, determine this output size.

CHECK

One artboard exists; Properties reports 1080 × 1350.

FIX

Select the artboard group rather than Layer 1. If height is 2400, correct its H property to 1350 before continuing; correction is not yet captured.

03 Make room for two alternatives

DOCUMENT: surname_AdPlanning_v01

SELECT: First artboard group in Layers

TOOLS / ROUTE: Artboard tool → + → Layers names

1. Select the Artboard tool nested under Move. Select the first artboard; use a side + to add an empty artboard, then add a third.
2. Double-click each artboard name in Layers: 01_MOOD, 02_SKETCH_A, 03_SKETCH_B.
3. Select each group and check Properties W 1080 / H 1350. Keep identical sketch sizes for a fair comparison.

Photoshop procedure not yet fully run. Native captures stop after creation of the first artboard with an incorrect height. Further per-action screenshots, correction, saved PSD and reopen/export proof are pending. This section needs a live teacher demonstration before student use.

WHY

One file keeps the visual proposal and alternative layouts available together.

CHECK

Three named groups appear; sketch sizes match.

FIX

A normal + adds an empty board; Option/Alt + duplicates contents. If you duplicated accidentally, keep the board and remove only unneeded duplicate content after checking the selected group.

04 Bring in your browser mood board

DOCUMENT: surname_AdPlanning_v01 + surname_MoodBoard_v01

SELECT: 01_MOOD

TOOLS / ROUTE: Free Excalidraw lab → PNG → File → Place Embedded

1. After naming the communication problem in stage 1, complete the linked free browser mood-board lab before Photoshop setup. No installation or account is needed for the Excalidraw editor. Make and explain image, colour and type choices for the brief.
2. Keep an editable .excalidraw master, a review PNG and the credited planning log. Confirm actual files exist and the master reopens in your school browser. Browser disk-save/file-picker/reopen verification is pending; do not rely on autosave.
3. With 01_MOOD selected in Photoshop, use File → Place Embedded for the mood-board PNG. Keep its proportions while resizing, commit with Enter/Return and check that its layer is inside 01_MOOD. This native transfer is not yet run.
4. Keep the separate .excalidraw master for mood-board edits. The PNG is a visual reference; your Photoshop sketch boards still need editable shape and text layers. Explain a reference feature, colour role and type role tied to this audience.

Photoshop procedure not yet fully run. Native captures stop after creation of the first artboard with an incorrect height. Further per-action screenshots, correction, saved PSD and reopen/export proof are pending. This section needs a live teacher demonstration before student use.

Open the linear free browser mood-board lab and action screenshots · Editable worked example · Actual worked PNG.

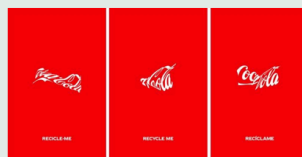
Read the credited real-campaign study log.

STUDY A FEATURE / MAKE YOUR OWN CHOICE



Follow the Arches / Cossette

Simplify the focal image.
Keep the message easy to find.



Recycle Me / Ogilvy

Study the relationship between
image and action text.



Public Theater / Pentagram

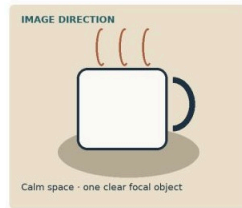
Energetic type may conflict
with our proposed calm tone.

Actual campaign images · credited teaching/criticism · rights remain with owners · not measured audience results

Actual campaign study: Cossette, Ogilvy and Pentagram. Copyright remains with owners.

NORTHCOAST / QUIET MOMENT

Constructed café practice / audience: people seeking a quiet break
Action: notice a calm invitation / tone: warm, calm, uncluttered



COLOUR ROLES

- Cream / background / #f4ead5
- Dark ink / main words / #193443
- Terracotta / accent / #b85a36

TYPE DIRECTION / simple sans serif; clear headline and detail

Find your quiet moment

Detail sample: a calm invitation with practical information kept readable.

Reason: one focal object and open space suggest calm; dark words carry information.

Credit: original Learning Studio cup illustration, supplied for class reuse. Constructed practice.

Genuine Excalidraw canvas capture: constructed practice board with image, labelled palette, type roles and reasons.

WHY

A browser mood board proposes the direction without installing another app. The PNG carries that proposal into the layout file.

CHECK

The board communicates image, colour, type and tone with reasons/credits. The editable browser master is retained; the placed reference belongs to 01_MOOD.

FIX

If only a PNG exists, save the editable browser scene too. If the PNG lands on the wrong Photoshop board, inspect Layers nesting before continuing.

SESSION B · LESSON 2

Sketch, compare and revise

70 minutes suggested: 5 recall/correction, 8 teacher model, 20 two sketches, 10 fair reader test, 12 revision, 10 save/export/reopen, 5 defence.

05 Sketch two genuinely different layouts

Recall first (from last lesson, no peeking):

1. What does a mood board communicate?
2. How is an artboard different from a layer?
3. Why do two sketch options need the same brief and size?

Say or write your answers, then check them against your file.

DOCUMENT: surname_AdPlanning_v01

SELECT: 02_SKETCH_A then 03_SKETCH_B

TOOLS / ROUTE: Rectangle tool (Shape) + Type tool; optional paper sketch import

1. In 02_SKETCH_A, make rough boxes for headline, focal image, supporting detail and next action. Use Rectangle in Shape mode and short Type labels; keep each element editable. Exact control/action screenshots are pending.
2. In 03_SKETCH_B, make a second composition with a different focal point or reading order. Keep the audience, required copy, palette and size fixed.
3. Write your predicted first → second → third read beside each sketch. Stop before effects, retouching or final polish. If drawing is difficult, draw two paper thumbnails, photograph them and Place Embedded on the two sketch boards.

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SAME DIRECTION · DIFFERENT READING ORDER

SKETCH A / SAME BRIEF

1080 x 1350 - layout hypothesis, not finished ad



SKETCH B / SAME BRIEF

1080 x 1350 - layout hypothesis, not finished ad



COMPARE A / B

Keep the audience, copy, palette and size fixed. Change the hierarchy.

Predict → ask a reader → record → revise

Teaching models drawn for this package. They do not depict Photoshop controls.

Authored layout models: A begins with the headline; B begins with the image. Neither is a guaranteed winner.

WHY

Two low-cost options allow a design decision before you invest in a polished layout.

CHECK

A and B differ in hierarchy or composition, rather than only a colour change.

FIX

If both sketches are the same, change the position and relative size of the primary message. Keep the actual communication problem fixed.

06 Test the reading order fairly

DOCUMENT: Both sketch boards and planning-log.txt

SELECT: A and B at the same viewing size

TOOLS / ROUTE: View → compare → ask → record

1. Show each sketch at the same size, briefly, to a reader. Before explaining your intention ask: “What did you notice first? What is the message? What would you do next?”
2. Record the reader’s actual words separately from your prediction. Check that all required information can be found.
3. Choose a direction using one observed strength and one weakness. If you have no reader, mark the record “self-check”; seek an actual reader later.

WHY

A test gives you evidence for a change. Praise alone does not locate a reading problem.

CHECK

Prediction and observation are separate; your choice refers to a visible feature and actual response.

FIX

If the question led the reader toward your intended answer, repeat with neutral questions. Never invent a response.

07 Keep the first idea and revise

DOCUMENT: surname_AdPlanning_v02

SELECT: Chosen sketch duplicated as 04_REVISED

TOOLS / ROUTE: Artboard tool → Option/Alt +; Layers; Save As

1. Keep A and B. Duplicate the chosen board with Option/Alt + and name it 04_REVISED. Change one feature linked to the recorded problem.
2. Retest with the same neutral questions. Record what changed and what remains uncertain.
3. Changed brief: your teacher changes the audience or display setting. Make a brief plan with less help: identify one choice you would retain and one you would change, with reasons.

Photoshop procedure not yet fully run. Native captures stop after creation of the first artboard with an incorrect height. Further per-action screenshots, correction, saved PSD and reopen/export proof are pending. This section needs a live teacher demonstration before student use.

WHY

Preserving the first idea makes your design process and learning inspectable.

CHECK

Your before/after shows the targeted change; the revision is tied to evidence.

FIX

If you changed everything, you cannot identify what helped. Return to the saved version and test one purposeful change.

08 Save, reopen and explain

DOCUMENT: surname_AdPlanning_v02.psd + exported boards

SELECT: All planning boards

TOOLS / ROUTE: File → Save As; File → Export → Artboards To Files

1. Save a layered local PSD in your class project folder. Keep the planning log and permitted source assets with it. Native save/reopen proof is pending.
2. Use File → Export → Artboards To Files for separate review images. Choose PNG and a local export folder; inspect the actual output. Exact export-dialog settings/screenshots are pending.
3. Reopen the saved PSD: confirm named boards, editable text/shapes and image nesting. Open the exported sketches separately and check size, readable labels and absence of clipped required information.
4. Explain the audience, one reference choice, the difference between A/B, the observed reader response and the resulting revision. Hand off through your teacher's current Student OS task only when that task has been assigned.

Photoshop procedure not yet fully run. Native captures stop after creation of the first artboard with an incorrect height. Further per-action screenshots, correction, saved PSD and reopen/export proof are pending. This section needs a live teacher demonstration before student use.

WHY

The editable source preserves decisions; exports let others review them without Photoshop.

CHECK

Saved PSD reopens; expected boards and layers remain; exports match the intended dimensions.

FIX

A PNG is not a layered master. If saving only an image, return to the document and save PSD. A local note is not a confirmed evidence submission.

BEFORE YOU SUBMIT

Student QA.

- ☐ Approved facts and audience/action recorded.
- ☐ References credited and permitted; palette/type roles annotated.
- ☐ A and B have distinct reading orders at equal size.
- ☐ Actual test result recorded honestly.
- ☐ Initial options retained; revised choice explained.
- ☐ Saved layered PSD reopens; exported boards checked.

EVIDENCE CONVERSATION

Keep it short and specific.

Open the shared Coach · Open Student OS. Use only your assigned task. No Form has been connected to this planning practice.

Who is the reader, and what action should follow?

Which reference feature influenced a choice, and why?

How do A and B differ in reading order?

What did your reader actually report? What did you revise?

What did your PSD reopen/export check show?

SOURCES AND AUTHORSHIP

Method references.

Excalidraw Free MIT-licensed browser editor; observed 8 October 2026 <https://github.com/excalidraw/excalidraw>

Adobe-New Create artboard documents · checked 8 October 2026 <https://helpx.adobe.com/photoshop/desktop/create-manage-layers/layout-design-tools/create-artboard-documents.html>

Adobe-Add Add artboards · checked 8 October 2026 <https://helpx.adobe.com/photoshop/desktop/create-manage-layers/layout-design-tools/add-artboards-current-document.html>

Adobe-Properties Artboard properties · checked 8 October 2026 <https://helpx.adobe.com/photoshop/desktop/create-manage-layers/layout-design-tools/artboard-properties.html>

Adobe-Place Place files · checked 8 October 2026 <https://helpx.adobe.com/photoshop/desktop/create-open-import-images/import-files/place-a-file-in-photoshop.html>

Adobe-Use Use artboards and export · checked 8 October 2026 <https://helpx.adobe.com/photoshop/desktop/create-manage-layers/get-started-layers/use-artboards-to-lay-out-designs.html>

Adobe-Mood Design processes and mood boarding · checked 8 October 2026 <https://blog.adobe.com/en/publish/2019/02/28/from-design-thinking-to-the-mood-boarding-6-commonly-used-design-processes-to-try-on-your-next-project>

NS Nova Scotia Communications Technology 11 course source <https://curriculum.novascotia.ca/english-programs/course/communications-technology-11>

Photo credits

Figures marked Illustration are drawn, not screenshots. Step values are starting points authored for this project. Draft for teacher review; not yet classroom-piloted.

Draft for teacher review. Native steps beyond the initial wrong-height artboard have not yet run; independent cold run pending. Practice notes stay in this browser until you save/copy them. No Form or evidence synchronization is claimed.